Running a coup d'etat: a look at the means

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For several years, I've been observing a specific player archetype I call the "Initiator"; An ambitious player who starts many events within a server and can lead to extreme changes if harnessed correctly. Throughout several different servers, I've seen players with varying degrees of ambition; some merely made dents of chaos, but others have blown craters within a server's trajectory. While I am still working on the theory of this type of player, I have decided to tell the recent tale of how an initiator became a key figure in the complete takeover of a Minecraft server's admin team and ownership.

The story starts roughly a year after the server's initial creation. After continuous effort, I became the sole provider of the server hardware, which gave me the leverage needed to enter the second highest spot in the admin team. Since the first season of the server, I had been experiencing the effects of poor moderation and management. Having had several building projects ruined over several seasons — one of which was griefed by the owner himself. I wanted to fix the griefing issues so that the other players wouldn't suffer from the lack of rule enforcement. The server owner, however, was an obstacle to any good changes. To create a system that adapted to the practical application of the rules, I resorted to inciting outrage within the playerbase to create the pressure for change. I created a court system that claimed to keep the powers that the owner and I held in check, but its true purpose was to give me the ability to categorize between violations such as the differences in severity that griefing can have.

The admin team created to help us ended up being filled with people only slightly more competent than the owner, who was the only one who could appoint new admins. They were rarely involved in any actual moderation and were essentially just regular players with a fancy title. There was this one problem player who held the favor of the owner, allowing him to wreak havoc on the server. No other player had ever pushed my capacity to enforce the rules that the owner himself wrote. He found ways to bypass anti-griefing systems and had the owner constantly argue in his favor whenever I tried to ban him. It didn't help that the owner's control over the Discord gave him the ability to constantly ping me while demanding to be unbanned. It was a textbook example of server mismanagement. I had been looking for a way to leverage my power without provoking the owner, and I found it when the Initiator, whom I shall refer to as "Player G," joined the server.

There was no question on whether Player G could be classified as an Initiator, for her ambition shined at a level that was impossible to ignore. Her first interactions on the server involved ideas for a complete overhaul of the members in administration. Seeing this, I spoke with her, hoping her bold methods would encourage more action from the owner. Little did I know that this would snowball into a conspiracy to take all power within the server. We had discussed the owner's passivity on the problematic nature of their favored player. She revealed that the player had been misogynistic, and it was concluded that we needed to mobilize the playerbase to confront and riot against the owner.

Player G was able to use her social media presence to create advertisements which attracted about 20 new members. Since the old playerbase had been inactive, she used the loud minority to demand better management and express rage over the problem player. The owner, panicking as expected, gave her admin permission in the hopes that she would only make the minimal amount of changes needed to meet her demands. Knowing that the owner would not dare to undo this change, she escalated the situation to create chaos within the server. Accusations, mostly of misogyny, were thrown against the admin team regardless of evidence. Even the older playerbase, slowly becoming aware of the situation, saw the opportunity for change to be more important than whether or not the things being said were true. Only the more intelligent players attempted to give the claims any scrutiny. Luckily, those players became frustrated with the situation and eventually left the server, removing themselves from being potential threats to our new regime. This, of course, was my cue to "negotiate" with Player G for the admin team — which I would eventually purge entirely. It eventually resulted in me obtaining ownership status of the Discord server, marking our plans as successful and completing the coup.

Hundreds of days of interacting with the owner and administration had given me the insight into their strengths and weaknesses. I knew that the owner wouldn't resist against the riots, and negotiated accordingly to strip him of his power. The psychological warfare tactics used to bombard the server chats will serve as proof to me of the power of the keyboard when wielded in mass. My experiences with Player G will make her a prime example of an Initiator, and I will study the exact traits that allowed for all this to happen. In the end, I decided to test a combination of two systems focusing on player interaction that I had been slowly developing over time. This test may serve as the basis of my theories, providing insight and methods to the larger Minecraft server community. This story shall serve to me as an example of how systems can be violently collapsed, and how power can be usurped.